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LEDs as a backlight source.

LED monitors use LEDs as a backlight instead of fluorescent lamps. Just as CRT and LCD monitors use RGB as primary colours to realise diverse colours, RGB LEDs are used in LED monitors to create white and acts as a backlight unit.

LED backlighting provides a wider colour gamut than previous monitors as LEDs' colour wavelengths have a higher purity level than fluorescent lamps. Additionally, as a semiconductor device, LED monitors have the added advantage of a longer life span,



Hitachi plasma TV

typically lasting over 100,000 hours.

Samsung is the first company to introduce and manufacture LED TVs in India. It has introduced three LED TV Series—6, 7 and 8—in the Indian market. While the Series 6 LED TVs are priced between Rs 125,000 (102cm) and Rs 150,000 (117cm), Series 7 LED TVs are priced between Rs 140,000 and Rs 180,000. Series 8 LED TVs are available in 140cm screen size priced at Rs 350,000.

LCD vs plasma vs LED TVs

Manish Sharma, associate professor at IIT Delhi, explains that plasma TVs produce better picture quality than LCD TVs due to their higher brightness, higher colour contrast, wider colour gamut and faster refresh rate. However, the brightness of plasma TVs goes down by about 30 per cent over a period of five years—reducing to 70 per cent of the original bright-

ness. This is one big factor contributing to lower sales of plasma TVs than LCD TVs.

On the other hand, despite the picture quality advantage of plasma TVs, people prefer LCD TVs because their costs have gone down. Also, these can be made thin like plasma TVs. Five years ago, LCDs were not bright enough. But today, their brightness and colour gamut are much better—though still less than plasma TVs.

The recently launched LED TVs are brighter than LCD TVs. Also, these can be made very thin—2.5 cm (one inch) or less. But this advantage of LED TVs is not very important in the Indian context: Thickness doesn't matter much to an average Indian consumer if a TV can be hung on the wall. However, in markets outside, like in Europe, USA and Japan, thickness

of the TV is the selling point. Also, LED TVs are very expensive at the moment, making sense only to the premium segment.

For low- and mid-end consumers, LCD TVs are a good option. Screen sizes like 107 cm (42 inches) and 127 cm (50 inches) are not suitable for most of the Indian households as rooms are generally small and people don't watch TV from a distance of six metres or more. (Ideally, the distance between the viewer and the screen should be three to six times the vertical height of the screen (which should be placed at the viewer's eye level))

Those who intend to set up home theatres can go for LED TVs, but for the same price they can get bigger-size LCD TVs. Maybe, in five years, LED TVs will go down in price. ●

The author is a deputy editor at Efy. The prices mentioned by her are only indicative and may vary